

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

American gangster

DIRECTOR

Francis Ford Coppola

WRITERS

Francis Ford Coppola
(screenplay); Mario Puzo
(novel and screenplay)

STARS

Marlon Brando, Al Pacino,
James Caan, Robert
Duvall, Diane Keaton

BEFORE

1931–32 *Little Caesar* (1931),
The Public Enemy (1931), and
Scarface (1932) whet the public
appetite for gangster movies.

AFTER

1974 *The Godfather: Part II* is
the hugely successful sequel,
focusing on Michael Corleone
(Al Pacino) as he becomes a
brutal Godfather.1990 *The Godfather: Part III*,
the less successful third movie,
concludes the Corleones' story.

Francis Ford Coppola's movie *The Godfather* changed the gangster-movie genre entirely, with its depiction of gangsters grappling with complex existential dilemmas, rather than as one-dimensional, lowlife hoodlums. Previously, all such gangster stories had been told from an outsider's point of view, and the gangsters themselves were seldom portrayed sympathetically.

The Godfather was also the first movie to show a Mafia organization from the inside. Its sprawling portrait of the Corleone family and their travails acquires the grandeur and scope of an ancient Greek tragedy, in which honor, duty, and loyalty to family are seen as the characters' main motivating forces, rather than criminal intent.

The background

The Godfather is based on a best-selling novel of the same name by Italian-American author Mario Puzo, which was published in 1969. Within a year, Paramount Pictures had commissioned Puzo to write the screenplay.

A successful screenwriter himself, Coppola, who had been hired as the director, had firm ideas

“Overflowing with life, rich with all the grand emotions and vital juices of existence, up to and including blood.”

Kenneth Turan
Los Angeles Times, 1997

of his own about how the script should be written, and he and Puzo worked together to complete the final draft. Coppola's insight was to see that the essence of the story, and the focus of the movie, should be the personal transition of Michael Corleone (Al Pacino) from respectable, law-abiding young man and decorated war hero to eventual head of a crime family, when he takes over from the Godfather, Don Vito Corleone (Marlon Brando). Coppola also saw the story as a metaphor for American free-market capitalism. The Corleones aspire to the American Dream and fight

Minute by minute

